

B.A. Minor BRITISH LITERATURE:19th CENTURY BA-EN-402

UNIT-1

Jane Austen: Pride and Prejudice

Pride and Prejudice

Pride and Prejudice, romantic novel by Jane Austen, published anonymously in three volumes in 1813. A classic of English literature, written with incisive wit and superb character delineation, it centers on the burgeoning relationship between Elizabeth Bennet, the daughter of a country gentleman, and Fitzwilliam Darcy, a rich aristocratic landowner. Upon publication, *Pride and Prejudice* was well received by critics and readers. The first edition sold out within the first year, and it never went out of print. The news that a wealthy young gentleman named Charles Bingley has rented the manor of Netherfield Park causes a great stir in the nearby village of Longbourn, especially in the Bennet household. The Bennets have five unmarried daughters—from oldest to youngest, Jane, Elizabeth, Mary, Kitty, and Lydia—and Mrs. Bennet is desperate to see them all married. After Mr. Bennet pays a social visit to Mr. Bingley, the Bennets attend a ball at which Mr. Bingley is present. He is taken with Jane and spends much of the evening dancing with her. His close friend, Mr. Darcy, is less pleased with the evening and haughtily refuses to dance with Elizabeth, which makes everyone view him as arrogant and obnoxious.

At social functions over subsequent weeks, however, Mr. Darcy finds himself increasingly attracted to Elizabeth's charm and intelligence. Jane's friendship with Mr. Bingley also continues to burgeon, and Jane pays a visit to the Bingley

mansion. On her journey to the house she is caught in a downpour and catches ill, forcing her to stay at Netherfield for several days. In order to tend to Jane, Elizabeth hikes through muddy fields and arrives with a spattered dress, much to the disdain of the snobbish Miss Bingley, Charles Bingley's sister. Miss Bingley's spite only increases when she notices that Darcy, whom she is pursuing, pays quite a bit of attention to Elizabeth.

When Elizabeth and Jane return home, they find Mr. Collins visiting their household. Mr. Collins is a young clergyman who stands to inherit Mr. Bennet's property, which has been "entailed," meaning that it can only be passed down to male heirs. Mr. Collins is a pompous fool, though he is quite enthralled by the Bennet girls. Shortly after his arrival, he makes a proposal of marriage to Elizabeth. She turns him down, wounding his pride. Meanwhile, the Bennet girls have become friendly with militia officers stationed in a nearby town. Among them is Wickham, a handsome young soldier who is friendly toward Elizabeth and tells her how Darcy cruelly cheated him out of an inheritance.

At the beginning of winter, the Bingleys and Darcy leave Netherfield and return to London, much to Jane's dismay. A further shock arrives with the news that Mr. Collins has become engaged to Charlotte Lucas, Elizabeth's best friend and the poor daughter of a local knight. Charlotte explains to Elizabeth that she is getting older and needs the match for financial reasons. Charlotte and Mr. Collins get married and Elizabeth promises to visit them at their new home. As winter progresses, Jane visits the city to see friends (hoping also that she might see Mr. Bingley). However, Miss Bingley visits her and behaves rudely, while Mr. Bingley fails to visit her at all. The marriage prospects for the Bennet girls appear bleak.

Characters

Pride and Prejudice is set in rural England at the turn of the 19th century, and it follows the Bennet family, which includes five very different sisters. The eldest, Jane, is sweet-tempered and modest. She is her sister Elizabeth's confidant and friend. Elizabeth, the heroine of the novel, is intelligent and high-spirited. She shares her father's distaste for the conventional views of society as to the importance of wealth and rank. The third daughter, Mary, is plain, bookish, and pompous, while Lydia and Kitty, the two youngest, are flighty and immature.

Mr. Bennet is the family patriarch. He is fond of his two eldest daughters—especially his favorite, Elizabeth—but takes a passive interest in the younger ones, ultimately failing to curb their childish instincts. An intelligent but eccentric and sarcastic man, he does not care for society's conventions and mocks his wife's obsession with finding suitable husbands for their daughters. As several scholars have noted, however, Mrs. Bennet is rightfully concerned. Because of an entail, the modest family estate is to be inherited by William Collins, Mr. Bennet's nephew, who is the next male in line. Indeed, as Austen scholar Mary Evans noted, "If Mrs. Bennett is slightly crazy, then perhaps she is so because she perceives more clearly than her husband the possible fate of her five daughters if they do not marry." Unfortunately, Mrs. Bennet's fervor and indelicacy often work against her interests. A woman of little sense and much self-pity, she indulges her lively youngest daughters.

Throughout the novel, the Bennet sisters encounter several eligible bachelors, including Charles Bingley, Darcy, Lieutenant George Wickham, and Collins. Bingley has recently let Netherfield estate, which neighbors the Bennets' home, Longbourn. Austen describes him as "good-looking and gentlemanlike; [having] a

pleasant countenance and easy, unaffected manners.” He has come by his fortune through his family’s interest in trade, which was seen as a less respectable means of obtaining wealth than by inheriting it, as his friend Darcy has done. Darcy is clearly a product of this hierarchical thinking: he believes in the natural superiority of the wealthy landed gentry. He is arrogant but perceptive.

That spring, Elizabeth visits Charlotte, who now lives near the home of Mr. Collins’s patron, Lady Catherine de Bourgh, who is also Darcy’s aunt. Darcy calls on Lady Catherine and encounters Elizabeth, whose presence leads him to make a number of visits to the Collins’s home, where she is staying. One day, he makes a shocking proposal of marriage, which Elizabeth quickly refuses. She tells Darcy that she considers him arrogant and unpleasant, then scolds him for steering Bingley away from Jane and disinheriting Wickham. Darcy leaves her but shortly thereafter delivers a letter to her. In this letter, he admits that he urged Bingley to distance himself from Jane, but claims he did so only because he thought their romance was not serious. As for Wickham, he informs Elizabeth that the young officer is a liar and that the real cause of their disagreement was Wickham’s attempt to elope with his young sister, Georgiana Darcy.

This letter causes Elizabeth to reevaluate her feelings about Darcy. She returns home and acts coldly toward Wickham. The militia is leaving town, which makes the younger, rather man-crazy Bennet girls distraught. Lydia manages to obtain permission from her father to spend the summer with an old colonel in Brighton, where Wickham’s regiment will be stationed. With the arrival of June, Elizabeth goes on another journey, this time with the Gardiners, who are relatives of the Bennets. The trip takes her to the North and eventually to the neighborhood of Pemberley, Darcy’s estate. She visits Pemberley, after making sure that Darcy is

away, and delights in the building and grounds, while hearing from Darcy's servants that he is a wonderful, generous master. Suddenly, Darcy arrives and behaves cordially toward her. Making no mention of his proposal, he entertains the Gardiners and invites Elizabeth to meet his sister.

Shortly thereafter, however, a letter arrives from home, telling Elizabeth that Lydia has eloped with Wickham and that the couple is nowhere to be found, which suggests that they may be living together out of wedlock. Fearful of the disgrace such a situation would bring on her entire family, Elizabeth hastens home. Mr. Gardiner and Mr. Bennet go off to search for Lydia, but Mr. Bennet eventually returns home empty-handed. Just when all hope seems lost, a letter comes from Mr. Gardiner saying that the couple has been found and that Wickham has agreed to marry Lydia in exchange for an annual income. The Bennets are convinced that Mr. Gardiner has paid off Wickham, but Elizabeth learns that the source of the money, and of her family's salvation, was none other than Darcy.

Now married, Wickham and Lydia return to Longbourn briefly, where Mr. Bennet treats them coldly. They then depart for Wickham's new assignment in the North of England. Shortly thereafter, Bingley returns to Netherfield and resumes his courtship of Jane. Darcy goes to stay with him and pays visits to the Bennets but makes no mention of his desire to marry Elizabeth. Bingley, on the other hand, presses his suit and proposes to Jane, to the delight of everyone but Bingley's haughty sister. While the family celebrates, Lady Catherine de Bourgh pays a visit to Longbourn. She corners Elizabeth and says that she has heard that Darcy, her nephew, is planning to marry her. Since she considers a Bennet an unsuitable match for a Darcy, Lady Catherine demands that Elizabeth promise to refuse him. Elizabeth spiritedly refuses, saying she is not engaged to Darcy, but she will not

promise anything against her own happiness. A little later, Elizabeth and Darcy go out walking together and he tells her that his feelings have not altered since the spring. She tenderly accepts his proposal, and both Jane and Elizabeth are married.

UNIT-2

Charlotte Bronte: Jane Eyre

Jane Eyre's appeal was partly due to the fact that it was written in the first person and often addressed the reader, creating great immediacy. In addition, Jane is an unconventional heroine, an independent and self-reliant woman who overcomes both adversity and societal norms.

Jane Eyre is a young orphan being raised by Mrs. Reed, her cruel, wealthy aunt. A servant named Bessie provides Jane with some of the few kindnesses she receives, telling her stories and singing songs to her. One day, as punishment for fighting with her bullying cousin John Reed, Jane's aunt imprisons Jane in the red-room, the room in which Jane's Uncle Reed died. While locked in, Jane, believing that she sees her uncle's ghost, screams and faints. She wakes to find herself in the care of Bessie and the kindly apothecary Mr. Lloyd, who suggests to Mrs. Reed that Jane be sent away to school. To Jane's delight, Mrs. Reed concurs.

Once at the Lowood School, Jane finds that her life is far from idyllic. The school's headmaster is Mr. Brocklehurst, a cruel, hypocritical, and abusive man. Brocklehurst preaches a doctrine of poverty and privation to his students while using the school's funds to provide a wealthy and opulent lifestyle for his own family. At Lowood, Jane befriends a young girl named Helen Burns, whose strong, martyrlike attitude toward the school's miseries is both helpful and displeasing to

Jane. A massive typhus epidemic sweeps Lowood, and Helen dies of consumption. The epidemic also results in the departure of Mr. Brocklehurst by attracting attention to the insalubrious conditions at Lowood. After a group of more sympathetic gentlemen takes Brocklehurst's place, Jane's life improves dramatically. She spends eight more years at Lowood, six as a student and two as a teacher.

After teaching for two years, Jane yearns for new experiences. She accepts a governess position at a manor called Thornfield, where she teaches a lively French girl named Adèle. The distinguished housekeeper Mrs. Fairfax presides over the estate. Jane's employer at Thornfield is a dark, impassioned man named Rochester, with whom Jane finds herself falling secretly in love. She saves Rochester from a fire one night, which he claims was started by a drunken servant named Grace Poole. But because Grace Poole continues to work at Thornfield, Jane concludes that she has not been told the entire story. Jane sinks into despondency when Rochester brings home a beautiful but vicious woman named Blanche Ingram. Jane expects Rochester to propose to Blanche. But Rochester instead proposes to Jane, who accepts almost disbelievingly.

The wedding day arrives, and as Jane and Mr. Rochester prepare to exchange their vows, the voice of Mr. Mason cries out that Rochester already has a wife. Mason introduces himself as the brother of that wife—a woman named Bertha. Mr. Mason testifies that Bertha, whom Rochester married when he was a young man in Jamaica, is still alive. Rochester does not deny Mason's claims, but he explains that Bertha has gone mad. He takes the wedding party back to Thornfield, where they witness the insane Bertha Mason scurrying around on all fours and growling like an animal. Rochester keeps Bertha hidden on the third story of Thornfield and pays Grace Poole to keep his wife under control. Bertha was the real cause of the

mysterious fire earlier in the story. Knowing that it is impossible for her to be with Rochester, Jane flees Thornfield.

Penniless and hungry, Jane is forced to sleep outdoors and beg for food. At last, three siblings who live in a manor alternatively called Marsh End and Moor House take her in. Their names are Mary, Diana, and St. John (pronounced “Sinjin”) Rivers, and Jane quickly becomes friends with them. St. John is a clergyman, and he finds Jane a job teaching at a charity school in Morton. He surprises her one day by declaring that her uncle, John Eyre, has died and left her a large fortune: 20,000 pounds. When Jane asks how he received this news, he shocks her further by declaring that her uncle was also his uncle: Jane and the Riverses are cousins. Jane immediately decides to share her inheritance equally with her three newfound relatives.

St. John decides to travel to India as a missionary, and he urges Jane to accompany him—as his wife. Jane agrees to go to India but refuses to marry her cousin because she does not love him. St. John pressures her to reconsider, and she nearly gives in. However, she realizes that she cannot abandon forever the man she truly loves when one night she hears Rochester’s voice calling her name over the moors. Jane immediately hurries back to Thornfield and finds that it has been burned to the ground by Bertha Mason, who lost her life in the fire. Rochester saved the servants but lost his eyesight and one of his hands. Jane travels on to Rochester’s new residence, Ferndean, where he lives with two servants named John and Mary.

At Ferndean, Rochester and Jane rebuild their relationship and soon marry. At the end of her story, Jane writes that she has been married for ten blissful years and that she and Rochester enjoy perfect equality in their life together. She says that after two years of blindness, Rochester regained sight in one eye and was able to behold their first son at his birth.

UNIT-3

Charles Dickens: Great Expectations

Great Expectations follows the childhood and young adult years of Pip a blacksmith's apprentice in a country village. He suddenly comes into a large fortune (his great expectations) from a mysterious benefactor. and moves to London where he enters high society.

Great Expectations by Charles Dickens tells the story of Pip, a young boy who grows up and learns many valuable life lessons about himself and others.

Pip, a young orphan living with his sister and her husband in the marshes of Kent, sits in a cemetery one evening looking at his parents' tombstones. Suddenly, an escaped convict springs up from behind a tombstone, grabs Pip, and orders him to bring him food and a file for his leg irons. Pip obeys, but the fearsome convict is soon captured anyway. The convict protects Pip by claiming to have stolen the items himself.

One day Pip is taken by his Uncle Pumblechook to play at Satis House, the home of the wealthy dowager Miss Havisham, who is extremely eccentric: she wears an old wedding dress everywhere she goes and keeps all the clocks in her house stopped at the same time. During his visit, he meets a beautiful young girl named Estella, who treats him coldly and contemptuously. Nevertheless, he falls in love with her and dreams of becoming a wealthy gentleman so that he might be worthy of her. He even hopes that Miss Havisham intends to make him a gentleman and marry him to Estella, but his hopes are dashed when, after months of regular visits to Satis House, Miss Havisham decides to help him become a common laborer in his family's business.

With Miss Havisham's guidance, Pip is apprenticed to his brother-in-law, Joe, who is the village blacksmith. Pip works in the forge unhappily, struggling to better his education with the help of the plain, kind Biddy and encountering Joe's malicious day laborer, Orlick. One night, after an altercation with Orlick, Pip's sister, known as Mrs. Joe, is viciously attacked and becomes a mute invalid. From her signals, Pip suspects that Orlick was responsible for the attack.

One day a lawyer named Jaggers appears with strange news: a secret benefactor has given Pip a large fortune, and Pip must come to London immediately to begin his education as a gentleman. Pip happily assumes that his previous hopes have come true—that Miss Havisham is his secret benefactor and that the old woman intends for him to marry Estella.

In London, Pip befriends a young gentleman named Herbert Pocket and Jaggers's law clerk, Wemmick. He expresses disdain for his former friends and loved ones, especially Joe, but he continues to pine after Estella. He furthers his education by studying with the tutor Matthew Pocket, Herbert's father. Herbert himself helps Pip learn how to act like a gentleman. When Pip turns twenty-one and begins to receive an income from his fortune, he will secretly help Herbert buy his way into the business he has chosen for himself. But for now, Herbert and Pip lead a fairly undisciplined life in London, enjoying themselves and running up debts. Orlick reappears in Pip's life, employed as Miss Havisham's porter, but is promptly fired by Jaggers after Pip reveals Orlick's unsavory past. Mrs. Joe dies, and Pip goes home for the funeral, feeling tremendous grief and remorse. Several years go by, until one night a familiar figure barges into Pip's room—the convict, Magwitch, who stuns Pip by announcing that he, not Miss Havisham, is the source of Pip's fortune. He tells Pip that he was so moved by Pip's boyhood kindness that he

dedicated his life to making Pip a gentleman, and he made a fortune in Australia for that very purpose.

Pip is appalled, but he feels morally bound to help Magwitch escape London, as the convict is pursued both by the police and by Compeyson, his former partner in crime. A complicated mystery begins to fall into place when Pip discovers that Compeyson was the man who abandoned Miss Havisham at the altar and that Estella is Magwitch's daughter. Miss Havisham has raised her to break men's hearts, as revenge for the pain her own broken heart caused her. Pip was merely a boy for the young Estella to practice on; Miss Havisham delighted in Estella's ability to toy with his affections.

As the weeks pass, Pip sees the good in Magwitch and begins to care for him deeply. Before Magwitch's escape attempt, Estella marries an upper-class lout named Bentley Drummle. Pip makes a visit to Satis House, where Miss Havisham begs his forgiveness for the way she has treated him in the past, and he forgives her. Later that day, when she bends over the fireplace, her clothing catches fire and she goes up in flames. She survives but becomes an invalid. In her final days, she will continue to repent for her misdeeds and to plead for Pip's forgiveness.

The time comes for Pip and his friends to spirit Magwitch away from London. Just before the escape attempt, Pip is called to a shadowy meeting in the marshes, where he encounters the vengeful, evil Orlick. Orlick is on the verge of killing Pip when Herbert arrives with a group of friends and saves Pip's life. Pip and Herbert hurry back to effect Magwitch's escape. They try to sneak Magwitch down the river on a rowboat, but they are discovered by the police, who Compeyson tipped off. Magwitch and Compeyson fight in the river, and Compeyson is drowned. Magwitch is sentenced to death, and Pip loses his fortune. Magwitch feels that his

sentence is God's forgiveness and dies at peace. Pip falls ill; Joe comes to London to care for him, and they are reconciled. Joe gives him the news from home: Orlick, after robbing Pumblechook, is now in jail; Miss Havisham has died and left most of her fortune to the Pockets; Biddy has taught Joe how to read and write. After Joe leaves, Pip decides to rush home after her and marry Biddy, but when he arrives there he discovers that she and Joe have already married.

Pip decides to go abroad with Herbert to work in the mercantile trade. Returning many years later, he encounters Estella in the ruined garden at Satis House. Drummle, her husband, treated her badly, but he is now dead. Pip finds that Estella's coldness and cruelty have been replaced by a sad kindness, and the two leave the garden hand in hand, Pip believing that they will never part again. (Note: Dickens's original ending to *Great Expectations* differed from the one described in this summary. The final Summary and Analysis section of this SparkNote provides a description of the first ending and explains why Dickens rewrote it.)

UNIT-4

Victorian Poetry: (a) Alfred Tennyson: 'The Lady of Shalott', 'Ulysses' Last The Lotos-Eate Together' rs'131 (b) Robert Browning: 'My Last Duchess', 'ThRide , `Porphyria's Lover'L11131 (c) Christina Rossetti: 'The Goblin Market'

The Lady of Shalott | Romantic Poetry, Victorian Era, Arthurian Legend | Britannica.

That said, most scholars understand "The Lady of Shalott" to be about the conflict between art and life. The Lady, who weaves her magic web and sings her song in a

remote tower, can be seen to represent the contemplative artist isolated from the bustle and activity of daily life.

"The Lady of Shalott" is a lyrical ballad by the 19th-century English poet **Alfred Tennyson** and one of his best-known works. Inspired by the 13th-century ...

"The Lady of Shalott" is a lyrical ballad by the 19th-century English poet Alfred Tennyson and one of his best-known works. Inspired by the 13th-century Italian short prose text *Donna di Scalotta*, the poem tells the tragic story of Elaine of Astolat, a young noblewoman stranded in a tower up the river from Camelot.

Tennyson wrote two versions of the poem, one published in 1832 (in *Poems*, incorrectly dated 1833),^[2] of 20 stanzas, the other in 1842, of 19 stanzas (also in a book named *Poems*), and returned to the story in "Lancelot and Elaine". The vivid medieval romanticism and enigmatic symbolism of "The Lady of Shalott" inspired many painters, especially the Pre-Raphaelites and their followers, as well as other authors and artists.

"The Lady of Shalott" has been adapted in various ways in later works of literature. Agatha Christie used the line "The mirror crack'd from side to side" as the title of her 1962 novel in which the poem itself plays a large part in the plot. In Lucy Maud Montgomery's *Anne of Green Gables* (1908), Anne Shirley reads various stanzas of the poem and acts out the Lady of Shalott's tragic end as she floats down the river. Patricia A. McKillip used an adaptation of the poem as a primary theme of her novel *The Tower at Stony Wood* (2000). Lisa Ann Sandell's novel *Song of the Sparrow* (2007) is a retelling of the story. Tennyson's poem is also used for narration and as a narrative device in Kaori Yuki's "Camelot Garden" (2008).^{[13][14]} In Jasper Fforde's novel *One of our Thursdays Is Missing* (2011), the Lady of Shalott appears as a character, possessing a mirror that allows characters in the Book World to see into the real world ("the Outland"). In *Half Sick of*

Shadows (2021) by Laura Sebastian, Elaine of Shalott is the main character and a close friend and advisor to King Arthur; the story primarily deals with the crowning of Arthur, but Elaine also has the ability to see future events through scrying at her loom.^[15]

Quotes from the poem have been included in many novels, including Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890), Eric Frank Russell's *Next of Kin* (1959), Muriel Spark's *The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie* (1961),^[16] Connie Willis' *To Say Nothing of the Dog* (1997), and Meg Cabot's *Avalon High* (2005). In some novels, the poem is also referenced within the plot by characters, as in Nancy Mitford's *Love in a Cold Climate* (1949),^[17] Bel Kaufman's *Up the Down Staircase* (1965), David Benedictus's *Floating Down to Camelot* (1985), Diana Wynne Jones' *Hexwood* (1993), Libba Bray's *A Great and Terrible Beauty* (2003), and Jilly Cooper's *Wicked!* (2006).

Its various lines have been turned into book titles by authors such as Jessica Anderson (*Tirra Lirra by the River*, 1978), Sharyn McCrumb (*Sick of Shadows*, 1984), Robin Klein (*All in the Blue Unclouded Weather*, 1991), and Alan Bradley (*I Am Half-Sick of Shadows*, 2011). It also inspired the title of Elizabeth Bishop's poem "The Gentleman of Shalott" (1946).

Music^[edit]

One of the first settings of the poem to music was by English composer Amy Horrocks who appeared at the 1898 Ballad Concert^[18] accompanying Ellen Bowick, for which Amy had composed a “graceful and picturesque”^[19] accompaniment of violin, cello and piano.^{[20][21]} Another early musical setting of the poem was probably a work for mezzo-soprano soloist, chorus and orchestra by the English composer Cyril Rootham, composed in 1909–1910. The only known performance of Rootham's op 33 *The Lady of Shalott* was

given in the School Hall at Eton College on 18 September 1999, with the Broadheath Singers and the Windsor Sinfonia conducted by Robert Tucker. In 1957–1958, Arthur Bliss (once a pupil of Cyril Rootham) composed a 40-minute ballet suite titled *The Lady of Shalott*.

Olivier Messiaen composed a piece for solo piano *La dame de Shalott* in 1917 based on Tennyson's poem as his first composition; however, this piece is unpublished. It has been recorded at least twice. In 1946, Phyllis Tate composed a setting of Tennyson's *The Lady of Shalott*, written for the 10th anniversary of the BBC Third Programme. Danish composer Bent Sørensen created a piece for viola solo, based on Waterhouse's painting *The Lady of Shalott*.

Canadian singer Loreena McKennitt adapted the poem to music, and featured it on her 1991 album *The Visit*, though some poem lines were removed. Dutch gothic metal band Autumn referred to "*The Lady of Shalott*" in their songs "*Who Has Seen Her Wave Her Hand*", "*Mirrors Magic Sights*", "*When Lust Evokes the Curse*", and "*Floating Towards Distress*" from their 2002 album *When Lust Evokes the Curse*, each song retelling parts of the story from the poem. The song titled "*Shalott*" on Emilie Autumn's 2006 album *Opheliac* tells the poem from her own perspective. The Band Perry's country music video "*If I Die Young*"^[22] makes clear visual references to "*The Lady of Shalott*": lead vocalist Kimberly Perry holds a book of poems by Tennyson as she lies in a boat, floating down a river like the Lady of Shalott (the boat in the Perry video is similar to some illustrations of the poem, such as the image by W. E. F. Britten).

The poem has been furthermore referred to or quoted in various ways in modern music. For instance, folk duo the Indigo Girls refer to the Lady of Shalott in "*Left Me a Fool*" from their 1987 album *Strange Fire* and Swedish pop band The Cardigans quotes it "*Give Me Your Eyes*", a bonus track on *Super Extra Gravity*.

British musician and singer Richard Thompson took the title for his 1994 album *Mirror Blue* from the poem.

Television[edit]

The poem forms the backbone of voice-over for the episode "Tracie's Story" (2012) of *Accused*. In *My Mother and Other Strangers* (2016), Tennyson's poem plays an important role.^[23]

The poem has been also often quoted in whole or in part within other television films and series. Examples of that include the *Upstairs, Downstairs* episode "The Understudy" (1975), *The Buccaneers* episode "Invasion" (1995), the *Endeavour* episode "Girl" (2013), and the *Tales of the City* episode "She Messy" (2019), as well as the BBC film *An Englishman Abroad* (1983).

“THE LOTUS EATERS”

Ulysses, who symbolizes the grieving poet, proclaims his resolution to push onward in spite of the awareness that “death closes all” (line 51). As Tennyson himself stated, the poem expresses his own “need of going forward and braving the struggle of life” after the loss of his beloved Hallam.

The “*Lotus Eaters*” episode is the fifth episode in *Ulysses*, and one of the shortest chapters in the novel. In this episode, Bloom begins wandering through Dublin, on his way to Paddy Dignam’s funeral. It is a hot summer day, and the humidity perpetuates a mood of sluggishness. Bloom, in his black funeral clothes, undoubtedly feels the haze of the summer heat. While he walks, he watches and comments on the scenes he sees on the Dublin street, providing commentary on Joyce’s Dublin and characterizing Bloom through his free-flowing thoughts. He sees a young boy, smoking and waiting for his father outside of a bar 10am.

Bloom imagines the “Far East” where the hot weather causes them to “Sleep six months out of twelve. Too hot to quarrel. Influence of the climate. Lethargy. Flowers of idleness...Petals too tired to. Sleeping sickness in the air.” (5.33-36). He thinks of Molly, at home, sleeping.

Bloom stops at the post office, producing a card to receive mail for Henry Flower, a pseudonym he developed for an ad he placed in the paper, a thinly disguised solicitation for a lady to help a gentleman with literary work (Gifford reminds us of Bloom’s ad: “Wanted smart lady typist to aid gentleman in literary work”) (Gifford, 85). It’s clear that he and Martha have exchanged some raunchy correspondence, and that there was little pretense about the “literary work” which the so-called Henry Flower mentioned in his ad. In this letter, Martha chastises Bloom for his earlier letter (the contents of which are unclear, but her question “Are you not happy in your home you poor little naughty boy?” can give us a hint) (5.246-7). He pockets the letter, noting in passing that there is something else in the envelope. As he feels it through his pocket, he speculates: “photo perhaps. Hair? No.” (5.80-81).

After he stops at the post office, he runs into his friend, C.P. McCoy, who asks Bloom about his mourning clothes. When Bloom reminds him it is because Paddy Dignam’s funeral is today, McCoy launches into a sentimental account of how he found out yesterday about Dignam’s death. As will become a pattern throughout the novel, Bloom’s thoughts wander during the conversation. Mostly ignoring McCoy, Bloom tries to catch sight of a woman’s stockings as she steps into a waiting car. Just at the critical moment (“Watch! Watch! Silk flash rich stockings white. Watch!”), his view is blocked by a passing tram, frustrating Bloom (5.130-

1). He laments, “Lost it. Curse your noisy pugnose. Feels locked out of it. Paradise and the peri.” (5.132-3).

Bloom and McCoy briefly talk shop about their singing wives. Bloom seems dismissive of Mrs. McCoy’s singing, though he is outwardly polite. He prefers Molly’s deeper voice, thinking Mrs. McCoy a “reedy freckled soprano” with a voice “nice enough...for a little ballad. No guts in it.” (5.184-5). McCoy asks Bloom agree to put his name on the list at the funeral, because he doesn’t think he’ll be able to make it. He seems uneasy but is relieved when Bloom agrees – true to his word, Bloom does actually do this in “Hades,” the next episode.

After McCoy is gone, Bloom opens the letter from Martha (to “Henry Flower”) – he finds that the object Martha has enclosed in the envelope is a pressed flower, presumably a reference to his pseudonym (which resembles his real name, Bloom). Interestingly, he actually puts the flower in his front pocket. This is almost a passively active move. He is aware that she could be anyone, and that she could very well be walking down the street and recognize him by the flower, visible out of his front pocket (“Might just walk into her here.”) (5.222), although it is unclear if this would really be enough for her to recognize and approach him.

After this, seemingly more or less on a whim, Bloom enters the church and sits in on a Catholic Mass. He observes the service from a psychological/emotional/low-knowledge-level distance of a non-Catholic. He recognizes the tranquilizing quality of the service, remarking on a man falling asleep by the confession box. He draws a comparison between Dublin’s alcoholics and the churchgoers, both groups wanting to numb themselves from the pain and frustration of Dublin life, stemming from colonialism and a struggling economy.

After Mass, Bloom goes to pick up lotion for Molly from the chemist. He's forgotten Molly's prescription, but has the chemist search for it in his records. While he waits, he thinks about the chemicals he is surrounded by, the combined forces of all of the sedatives in the room, with which the chemist spends his days. He decides to come back later.

Bloom also pockets the lemon soap to come back and pay for it when he comes back. He never does this, although he does reference the soap in his pocket at several points later in *Ulysses*. After this point, it's implied, he goes to the funeral and meets up with his fellow mourners, among them Martin Cunningham and Stephen's father, Simon Dedalus. The events of the funeral are detailed in "Hades."

Homeric Parallels

The section in the original *Odyssey* addressing the Lotus Eaters is fairly brief. (This chapter of *Ulysses* is similarly brief.) Odysseus recounts his struggles to Lord Alcinous, particularly leading up to the more involved tale of the Cyclops. This tale, then, forms the backdrop of Odysseus's sufferings at the time when he meets the Cyclops, and in the time before he arrives in the kingdom of Lord Alcinous, at which point he tells this tale. Odysseus recounts of his men, having landed on the island of the Lotus Eaters:

They fell in, soon enough, with the Lotos Eaters,
who showed no will to do us harm, only
offering the sweet Lotos to our friends—
but those who ate this honeyed plant, the Lotos,
never cared to report, nor to return:
they longed to stay forever, browsing on

that native bloom, forgetful of their homeland.

(Homer, Book 9, Lines 98-104)

A foundational part of the *Odyssey*'s ethos is loyalty to one's homeland and one's family. Temptations, as well as nearly impassible obstacles, crop up throughout Odysseus's journey which often make it seem easier or even preferable to give up and make a life somewhere else, rather than persevere in returning to Ithaca.

Odysseus's overpowering desire to go home and see his family inspires some of his most ingenious problem solving and valiant battles.

The evil of the Lotus Eaters, then, though they are hospitable and kind, is that Odysseus's men turn "forgetful of their homeland," for which they've fought and killed, and to which they are attempting to return. In his re-telling of the Lotus Eaters, Joyce seems to comment on the Irish, as well, as "forgetful of their homeland" – there is a sense of lost identity during this period of Irish history. The men are listless and often out of work. They have been colonized by the English and become absorbed in the conglomerate of the British Empire. This loss of identity, or 'forgetfulness,' manifests itself in this sense of aimless wandering – no one really seems to have a place to be, or to take their jobs seriously.

Similar to its presence in the *Odyssey*, this chapter of *Ulysses* is somewhat transitional: in "Calypso," we are introduced to the sleepy allure of Molly, resting quietly and not speaking, yet shaping Bloom's thoughts and actions for the rest of the novel. She hangs over the narration, potent with the infidelity that she will commit that afternoon and powerful in Bloom's dread and apprehension. Bloom's distractions from going home continue well into the night, as he procrastinates to avoid reckoning with his wife's infidelity.

Fantasies and Floating Subconscious

Throughout the novel, we experience narrative working on different levels. While witnessing the narrative of the day's events, the narration reporting what characters say or do weaves in and out of Bloom's thoughts and his many distractions.

Through the prism of Bloom's observations and rich inner life, with near-constant and instantaneous reflection on what he observes, this chapter examines the idea of fantasy and suspension from reality.

The first and perhaps most blatant example is Bloom's secret correspondence with Martha Clifford, via his pseudonym, Henry Flower. Rather than have an actual affair, Bloom prefers one of words and of possibility. The reality of an affair with Martha would be inevitably disappointing, Bloom reflects, and would be "as bad as a row with Molly." (5.271-2). Bloom maintains his faithfulness to Molly, ultimately, while attempting to vent some of his sexual frustration from his marriage.

The idea of the affair is more appealing than its likely reality. In fact, the idea of the entire thing is to escape reality, not to alter the existing reality – its separation from reality is its purpose and the reason it can continue to exist. (Also, he still hopes to fix things with Molly, but is trying to be patient – which we find out later in "Penelope," she doesn't want him to be, and has been waiting for him to openly address the issues in their marriage.)

The line also evokes a sense of paradise and its periphery. Bloom feels like he is in purgatory, existing around the edges of differently imaged possibilities for his reality. This is particularly true in this chapter, but continues throughout the day that Ulysses spans– the slow, circuitous voyage home to avoid the consequences of

a dissolving marriage – or, perhaps, to seek inspiration and return to face the music and reconcile. The paradise of reconciliation hovers just out of reach, as do the thousand other strands of tempting possibilities, like Martha, or the silk stockings. Bloom contemplates an affair with Martha, deciding against consummating it, realizing that the reality of such an affair would be unsatisfying and make it even more difficult to reconcile with Molly. He thinks, “Could meet one Sunday after the rosary. Thank you: not having any. Usual love scrimmage. Then running round corners. Bad as a row with Molly. Cigar has a cooling effect. Narcotic.” (5.270-2). Bloom likes to imagine, rather than to act on fantasies (foreshadowing his encounter with Gerty in the “Nausicaa” episode). As Harry Blamires writes, “One should note that Bloom’s affair with Martha Clifford, now to be explored, is an inactive experiment in mental self-indulgence.” (Blamires, 25).

Similarly, Joyce and Bloom seem to suggest that these little escapes from reality are what make life bearable. Throughout the day, Bloom avoids going home, distracting himself and taking wide, looping routes around Dublin to avoid thinking about and openly confronting his wife’s affair. Ulysses, the odyssey of a day, reflects on the little things we do to help us get through life. Bloom daydreams, imagines the Dead Sea and the Orient, mentally escaping the drudgery with his imagination.

It seems, as we experience his thoughts, that we are hovering just above his subconscious. In the narration style, we see these creep in (intrusive thoughts about Molly and their marital problems, her likely affair with Boylan), but he always has some scene that he’s imagining, or remembering, or some larger problem in society, technology, or business that he is trying to work out. In this episode, for example, he tries to recall what his physics teacher in high school taught them

about Archimedes' Law, to scientifically muse on the Dead Sea as a part of his Far East fantasy.

This episode, and the previous one, are good for setting up Bloom as a character, situating him as an observer and a dreamer, always a degree removed socially, but invested emotionally and mentally in the fabric of Dublin.

In this chapter, some of the repeating phrases that cycle through Ulysses are introduced: "What is home without Plumtree's Potted Meat? Incomplete. With it an abode of bliss?" (5.144-7). This ad and variations of it recur in Bloom's stream of consciousness throughout the text. The nonsense song on one of the first pages, "tooraloom, tooraloom, tay" is also repeated on and off throughout Ulysses.

In addition to the cyclical thoughts, generally more trivial or innocuous, Bloom's subconscious continually introduces thoughts of a darker nature, before dismissing them. When thinking about the theater, he is reminded of his father's love for the theater, which makes him think of his father's suicide: "Poor papa! Poor man! I'm glad I didn't go into the room to look at his face. That day! O, dear! Ffoo! Well, perhaps it was best for him." (5.207-9). His father's suicide, his son Rudy's premature death, and Molly's affair cycle painfully through his thoughts, often in short, anxious sentences. The reader can feel Bloom's resistance to fully indulge the thoughts, and his willingness to be distracted by what he observes externally.

Even so early in the novel (still just 10am on Bloom's long, long day), we see his fantasy of home-coming and reconciliation with Molly, dream-like as he projects it through his Far East musings (Molly's foreign-ness, the Spanish side of her, explains in part his foreign fantasies, or perhaps her foreignness is part of what seems to draw him to her). He imagines his return as "She listens with big dark soft

eyes. This passage also corresponds to what is happening in the *Odyssey* at this point – in the Lotus Eaters section, Odysseus is recounting strange things he’s seen, not experiencing them in ‘real-time’ so to speak. We retroactively experience them as he tells his tale in Alcinous’s court.

Lethargy and Sedatives in “The Lotus Eaters”

One of the most consistent qualities of turn of the century Dublin, as depicted by Joyce, is its stagnation. Its men are frustrated, often out of work, and feeling disenfranchised and emasculated by British colonialism. (The Citizen in “Cyclops” and his fellow bar patrons are great examples of this.) In this episode, this stagnation is enacted through stifling humidity. We are shown all the ways which Dublin has tried to anesthetize itself from this frustration and pain.

The heat of this chapter is palpable in its hazy, humid language: “Mr Bloom turned his largelidded eyes with unhasty friendliness” (5.150). There is a drunken kind of sloshing of the chapter (even though all of the drinking in this novel comes later). Bloom thinks about the port being carried on the freight train:

“Barrels bumped in his head: dull porter slopped and churned inside. The bungholes sprang open and a huge dull flood leaked out, flowing together, winding through mudflats all over the level land, a lazy pooling swirl of liquor bearing along wideleaved flowers of its froth.”

The floral language, as well, seems to gesture at this chapter’s Odyssean parallel. This warm, humid stupefaction of Dublin recalls the tropical world of the Lotus Eaters.

Bloom, in his detachment in creed and tradition, also observes the Mass from an emotional distance. The Church, which Marx once described as “the opiate of the masses,” here provides the opiate of the Mass. Bloom describes the image of an “Old fellow asleep near that confessionbox. Hence all the snores. Blind faith. Safe in the arms of kingdom come. Lulls all pain. Wake this time next year.” (5.366-8)

Bloom notes the similarities between alcoholism of Dublin and the communion – he says the wine “Makes it more aristocratic than for example if he drank what they are used to Guinness’s porter or some temperance beverage” (5.387-8). Both are a means of numbing pain and perhaps escaping the drudgery of life in some sort of transcendent feeling — and both are literally alcohol, although taking Communion is a far cry from binge drinking. This episode examines the means of numbing or abstracting oneself from hard, physical reality.

This exploration of religion, and more specifically Irish Catholicism, from a detached vantage point is characteristic of Joyce’s work, and more broadly of modernist literature. While many would argue that this detachment is a result of secularization (what Pericles Lewis refers to as the “secularization hypothesis”), in fact, it seems as though it is less that the churches have lost all sacredness, and more that the spiritual need which the church is designed to fill has been re-conceptualized. Lewis writes, in his essay on “Church Going in the Modern Novel,” that “The modernists’ attempts to describe forms of experience that would traditionally have been called “religious” reflects a blurring of the lines between the sacred and the profane. Precisely as the modernists turn away from institutional religion, they seek forms of sacredness and possibilities of ritual in the profane world.” (Lewis, 671). Therefore, Bloom appreciates the Catholic Mass he observes for its communal and spiritually soothing properties, even while sacrilegiously

comparing the wine to “Guinness’s porter,” and drawing a line from the soothing Mass to the way others in Dublin have turned to drink — perhaps for similar reasons to those who find comfort in the Mass and cling to their religion for solace.

Later, Bloom visits the chemist to pick up lotion for Molly. He thinks about the role of drugs in separating those who take them from reality, and reflects on the role of the chemist who sells them:

“The alchemists. Drugs age you after mental excitement. Lethargy then...Living all the day among herbs, ointments, disinfectants...Enough stuff here to chloroform you...Chloroform. Overdose of laudanum. Sleeping draughts.”

He seems to further connect these drugs to the Mass, and to the alcoholism, in the sense that they provide a means of detaching from reality. He also connects them to the overall sense of drowsiness that pervades the chapter and connects to the Homeric parallel of the Lotus Eaters.

The chapter closes with Bloom imagining himself floating in the bath, referring, at the end to his phallic “flower” lazing in the bath (this also references back to his letters to Martha and his pseudonym, Henry Flower, and perhaps is a cheeky nod at this and the Lotus Eaters parallel). After he leaves the chemist’s shop (and this daydream) behind, the chapter ends. The next chapter, “Hades,” begins with him getting into the carriage with Martin Cunningham, Simon Dedalus, and company, to go to Paddy Dignam’s funeral.

“My Last Duchess” - “My Last Duchess” is a dramatic monologue written by Victorian poet Robert Browning in 1842. In the poem, the Duke of Ferrara uses a painting of his former wife as a conversation piece. The Duke speaks about his

former wife's perceived inadequacies to a representative of the family of his bride-to-be, revealing his obsession with controlling others in the process. Browning uses this compelling psychological portrait of a despicable character to critique the objectification of women and abuses of power.

Summary

This poem is loosely based on historical events involving Alfonso, the Duke of Ferrara, who lived in the 16th century. The Duke is the speaker of the poem, and tells us he is entertaining an emissary who has come to negotiate the Duke's marriage (he has recently been widowed) to the daughter of another powerful family. As he shows the visitor through his palace, he stops before a portrait of the late Duchess, apparently a young and lovely girl. The Duke begins reminiscing about the portrait sessions, then about the Duchess herself. His musings give way to a diatribe on her disgraceful behavior: he claims she flirted with everyone and did not appreciate his "gift of a nine-hundred-years- old name." As his monologue continues, the reader realizes with ever-more chilling certainty that the Duke in fact caused the Duchess's early demise: when her behavior escalated, "[he] gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together." Having made this disclosure, the Duke returns to the business at hand: arranging for another marriage, with another young girl. As the Duke and the emissary walk leave the painting behind, the Duke points out other notable artworks in his collection.

Form

"My Last Duchess" comprises rhyming pentameter lines. The lines do not employ end-stops; rather, they use enjambment—that is, sentences and other grammatical units do not necessarily conclude at the end of lines. Consequently, the rhymes do not create a sense of closure when they come, but rather remain a subtle driving

force behind the Duke's compulsive revelations. The Duke is quite a performer: he mimics others' voices, creates hypothetical situations, and uses the force of his personality to make horrifying information seem merely colorful. Indeed, the poem provides a classic example of a dramatic monologue: the speaker is clearly distinct from the poet; an audience is suggested but never appears in the poem; and the revelation of the Duke's character is the poem's primary aim.

Analysis

But Browning has more in mind than simply creating a colorful character and placing him in a picturesque historical scene. Rather, the specific historical setting of the poem harbors much significance: the Italian Renaissance held a particular fascination for Browning and his contemporaries, for it represented the flowering of the aesthetic and the human alongside, or in some cases in the place of, the religious and the moral. Thus the temporal setting allows Browning to again explore sex, violence, and aesthetics as all entangled, complicating and confusing each other: the lushness of the language belies the fact that the Duchess was punished for her natural sexuality. The Duke's ravings suggest that most of the supposed transgressions took place only in his mind. Like some of Browning's fellow Victorians, the Duke sees sin lurking in every corner. The reason the speaker here gives for killing the Duchess ostensibly differs from that given by the speaker of "Porphyria's Lover" for murder Porphyria; however, both women are nevertheless victims of a male desire to inscribe and fix female sexuality. The desperate need to do this mirrors the efforts of Victorian society to mold the behavior—sexual and otherwise—of individuals. For people confronted with an increasingly complex and anonymous modern world, this impulse comes naturally: to control would seem to be to conserve and stabilize. The Renaissance was a time when morally dissolute men like the Duke exercised absolute power, and as such it is a fascinating study for the Victorians: works like this imply that, surely, a time

that produced magnificent art like the Duchess's portrait couldn't have been entirely evil in its allocation of societal control—even though it put men like the Duke in power.

A poem like “My Last Duchess” calculatedly engages its readers on a psychological level. Because we hear only the Duke's musings, we must piece the story together ourselves. Browning forces his reader to become involved in the poem in order to understand it, and this adds to the fun of reading his work. It also forces the reader to question his or her own response to the subject portrayed and the method of its portrayal. We are forced to consider, Which aspect of the poem dominates: the horror of the Duchess's fate, or the beauty of the language and the powerful dramatic development? Thus by posing this question the poem firstly tests the Victorian reader's response to the modern world—it asks, Has everyday life made you numb yet?—and secondly asks a question that must be asked of all art—git queries, Does art have a moral component, or is it merely an aesthetic exercise? In these latter considerations Browning prefigures writers like Charles Baudelaire and Oscar Wilde.

'The Ride , `Porphyria's Lover'

Porphyria's lover is a dramatic monologue about a man who is unable to cope with his emotions towards his lover so strangles her. He proceeds to spend all night with her corpse and appears to be more in love with her when she is dead than alive.

Porphyria (por-FEAR-e-uh) refers to a group of rare disorders that result from a buildup of natural chemicals called porphyrins in the body. Porphyrins are needed to make heme, a part of hemoglobin. Hemoglobin is a protein in red blood cells.

Summary

“Porphyria’s Lover,” which first appeared in 1836, is one of the earliest and most shocking of Browning’s dramatic monologues. The speaker lives in a cottage in the countryside. His lover, a blooming young woman named Porphyria, comes in out of a storm and proceeds to make a fire and bring cheer to the cottage. She embraces the speaker, offering him her bare shoulder. He tells us that he does not speak to her. Instead, he says, she begins to tell him how she has momentarily overcome societal strictures to be with him. He realizes that she “worship[s]” him at this instant. Realizing that she will eventually give in to society’s pressures, and wanting to preserve the moment, he wraps her hair around her neck and strangles her. He then toys with her corpse, opening the eyes and propping the body up against his side. He sits with her body this way the entire night, the speaker remarking that God has not yet moved to punish him.

Looking for a briefer summary of “Porphyria’s Lover” and the other poems in this guide? Read the Sparklet summaries of Robert Browning’s poetry.

Form

“Porphyria’s Lover,” while natural in its language, does not display the colloquialisms or dialectical markers of some of Browning’s later poems. Moreover, while the cadence of the poem mimics natural speech, it actually takes the form of highly patterned verse, rhyming ABABB. The intensity and asymmetry

of the pattern suggests the madness concealed within the speaker's reasoned self-presentation.

This poem is a dramatic monologue—a fictional speech presented as the musings of a speaker who is separate from the poet. Like most of Browning's other dramatic monologues, this one captures a moment after a main event or action. Porphyria already lies dead when the speaker begins. Just as the nameless speaker seeks to stop time by killing her, so too does this kind of poem seek to freeze the consciousness of an instant.

Analysis

“Porphyria's Lover” opens with a scene taken straight from the Romantic poetry of the earlier 19th century. While a storm rages outdoors, giving a demonstration of nature at its most sublime, the speaker sits in a cozy cottage. This is the picture of rural simplicity—a cottage by a lake, a rosy-cheeked girl, a roaring fire. However, once Porphyria begins to take off her wet clothing, the poem leaps into the modern world. She bares her shoulder to her lover and begins to caress him; this is a level of overt sexuality that has not been seen in poetry since the Renaissance. We then learn that Porphyria is defying her family and friends to be with the speaker; the scene is now not just sexual, but transgressively so. Illicit sex out of wedlock presented a major concern for Victorian society; the famous Victorian “prudery” constituted only a backlash to what was in fact a popular obsession with the theme: the newspapers of the day reveled in stories about prostitutes and unwed mothers. Here, however, in “Porphyria's Lover,” sex appears as something natural, acceptable, almost wholesome: Porphyria's girlishness and affection take prominence over any hints of immorality.

For the Victorians, modernity meant numbness: urban life, with its constant overstimulation and newspapers full of scandalous and horrifying stories, immunized people to shock. Many believed that the onslaught of amorality and the constant assault on the senses could be counteracted only with an even greater shock. This is the principle Browning adheres to in “Porphyria’s Lover.” In light of contemporary scandals, the sexual transgression might seem insignificant; so Browning breaks through his reader’s probable complacency by having Porphyria’s lover murder her; and thus he provokes some moral or emotional reaction in his presumably numb audience. This is not to say that Browning is trying to shock us into condemning either Porphyria or the speaker for their sexuality; rather, he seeks to remind us of the disturbed condition of the modern psyche. In fact, “Porphyria’s Lover” was first published, along with another poem, under the title *Madhouse Cells*, suggesting that the conditions of the new “modern” world served to blur the line between “ordinary life”—for example, the domestic setting of this poem—and insanity—illustrated here by the speaker’s action. This poem, like much of Browning’s work, conflates sex, violence, and aesthetics. Like many Victorian writers, Browning was trying to explore the boundaries of sensuality in his work. How is it that society considers the beauty of the female body to be immoral while never questioning the morality of language’s sensuality—a sensuality often most manifest in poetry? Why does society see both sex and violence as transgressive? What is the relationship between the two? Which is “worse”? These are some of the questions that Browning’s poetry posits. And he typically does not offer any answers to them: Browning is no moralist, although he is no libertine either. As a fairly liberal man, he is confused by his society’s simultaneous embrace of both moral righteousness and a desire for sensation; “Porphyria’s Lover” explores this contradiction.

"Porphyria's Lover" is a poem by the British poet Robert Browning, first published in 1836. Along with "**My Last Duchess**," it has become one of Browning's most famous dramatic monologues—due in no small part to its shockingly dark ending. In the poem, the speaker describes being visited by his passionate lover, Porphyria. After realizing how much she cares for him, however, the speaker strangles Porphyria and then props her lifeless body up beside him. He then concludes the poem by announcing that God has yet to punish him for this murder. While the speaker is often taken to be a madman, his (very twisted) motivations seem clear: in killing Porphyria, he takes control over her, transforming her into an obedient object that will remain "pure" forever.

Goblin Market Summary

Each morning and evening young women hear the cry of the **goblin men**, who seductively describe the **fruits** they're selling and urge the young women to "come buy." One evening, sisters **Laura** and **Lizzie** hear the goblins' call while visiting a brook to draw water. They grow fearful and crouch down to hide themselves. Lizzie warns Laura not to look and covers her own eyes for protection, but the incurably curious Laura looks directly at the goblins. Laura describes the goblin men's odd movements and wonders where the luscious and unusual fruit they're selling might have grown. Still, Lizzie is steadfast in her refusal to look and warns Laura once again that the goblin men mean to harm them. Lizzie then puts her fingers in her ears to block the sound of the goblins' cries and runs away, leaving Laura on her own.

Laura chooses to stay and watch the goblins. She notices that they share physical characteristics with animals, including doves, rats, wombats, and cats, and have kind, pleasant voices. Fascinated, she stretches her neck toward them. The goblins approach Laura and seem delighted to find her alone. Laura wants to buy their fruit but has no money to offer in exchange. The goblins take a lock of Laura's hair as payment instead, and she then begins ravenously eating the fruit.

Get the entire Goblin Market LitChart as a printable PDF.

After gorging herself, Laura gathers up a fruit pit and, in a state of bewilderment, returns home to find her sister waiting up for her. Lizzie scolds Laura for staying out so late and reminds her of the fate of **Jeanie**, a young woman who, like Laura, accepted fruit from the goblins. After eating the fruit, Jeanie was abandoned by the goblins, pined away, and died. Now, no flowers will grow on her grave. Laura tries to reassure her sister, promising to bring back fruit from the goblins for Lizzie to try. Laura describes the fruit as otherworldly and unbelievably delicious. The two sisters go to sleep enfolded in one another's arms.

The next evening, when Laura and Lizzie return to the brook to draw water, Laura tries to delay their departure so that she might meet the goblins again. But try as she might, she cannot hear their calls. This greatly distresses Laura, who fears that she will never again eat the goblin fruit that she craves. The sisters return home, but Laura's heart aches. They go to bed, and Laura gnashes her teeth and weeps as she grieves for the lost fruit.

Days pass, and Laura pines for the fruit. She listens in the hopes of once more hearing the goblins, but she never again hears their cry. In her despair, Laura's hair begins to turn gray and she ages prematurely. One day, she remembers the fruit pit she took back with her after first meeting the goblins. Although she plants it in a sunny spot and waters it with her tears, it never grows. Laura becomes listless,

refusing to perform her household duties or to eat. The once-active Laura now spends her days sitting by the chimney nook.

Fearing that Laura will die, Lizzie resolves to find the goblins and purchase some fruit for her sister. Lizzie knows that she will be putting herself in danger, but she nevertheless puts a silver coin in her purse and goes to the brook at twilight. For the first time, she actively listens and looks for the goblins.

The goblins are delighted to find Lizzie looking for them. They hug, kiss, and caress her as they try to tempt her to eat their fruit. Lizzie tosses them a coin, but the goblins try to persuade her to stay and eat with them. She refuses, saying she must return home to her sister, and asks for her penny back if they will not sell their fruit. At this, the goblins become furious and begin to attack Lizzie. They call her proud and uncivil, stamp on her feet, scratch her, pull her hair out, and try to squeeze the fruit against her mouth to make her eat it. Yet despite the viciousness of the goblins' attack, Lizzie refuses to give in. Finally, the goblins realize their efforts are futile and they toss back her penny before departing, leaving Lizzie alone with the fruit juices dripping down her face.

In a daze, Lizzie runs home. She calls out to her sister and tells her to drink the juice from her face. Laura is horrified at first, fearing that Lizzie has eaten the fruit herself. Yet as Laura begins to taste the now-bitter juice, she behaves as if she is possessed, leaping, singing, tearing her robe, wringing her hands, and beating her breast. She loses consciousness and falls down.

Lizzie keeps watch over Laura throughout the night, checking her pulse and breathing, giving her water, and fanning her to keep her cool. By the time Laura wakes at dawn, a transformation has taken place. Laura's youth is restored along, and she embraces her sister. Years later, when Laura and Lizzie are both wives and

mothers, Laura warns their children about the predatory goblin men and their dangerous fruit. More importantly, she shares the story of how her sister braved the goblin men to save her.

Christina Rossetti's "Goblin Market" is a narrative poem. The poem is distinguished by its rigid ethical standards and stress on conventional ideals. It was first issued in 1862, during the Victorian era. It tells a narrative with characters, a story, and a distinct timeline.

Laura and Lizzie's encounters as they come into contact with the goblin traders and their alluring fruits are recounted in the poem, which has a sequential narrative framework. The poem's narrative structure enables the investigation of various issues and the ongoing growth of characters.

The poem is divided into two sections, each having its narrative flow. The goblin traders and their delectable fruits are introduced in the first section, which Laura can't resist. She eats prohibited fruits, weakening and making her sick. The poem's second section describes Lizzie's efforts to rescue her sister by purchasing the fruits from the goblin traders and taking them to her sister Laura for her to snack on.

The Theme of The Poem "Goblin Market" explores female sexuality and desire as one of its main themes. The poem explores the repercussions of giving in to such cravings and uses the goblin fruit as a metaphor for sexual seduction. It is possible to interpret Laura's initial attraction to the fruits and her eventual desire for more as a metaphor for feelings of sexuality and discovery. But her acts are shown to affect her well-being negatively, and she eventually needs her sister's help to turn things around.

The poem also depicts the goblin men as charming and cunning characters. They deploy enticing tunes, seductive words, and other strategies to seduce the women. Their behavior can be interpreted as a critique of social norms and a warning against giving in to outside pressure.

Christina Rossetti: Poems Summary and Analysis of "Goblin Market" (1862)

Summary:

Every evening, when sisters Lizzie and Laura go to fetch water from a nearby stream, they must listen to the tempting calls of goblin men selling delicious fruit. Lizzie fears the goblins and admonishes her sister to do the same. When they catch sight of the goblins displaying their wares on golden platters, Lizzie runs home, but Laura is entranced. Despite the goblins' demonic appearance, resembling cats, rats, snails and covered in whiskers, Laura hears only the coo of doves. The goblins see her and repeat their cry. Although Laura has no money, the goblins accept a lock of her hair as payment for the fruit. Laura drinks her fill of fruit juice and returns home, intoxicated by the sweet nectars. She brings one fruit stone (pit) home with her.

Lizzie meets Laura at the gateway to their home and scolds her sister for returning late. She recounts the tale of their friend Jeanie, who ate a piece of the goblin fruit and then pined away to her death because she could not get any more. Laura assures her sister that all is well and that she plans to buy enough fruit for both of them the next day. The sisters proceed with their housework. The next day, Laura discovers that she cannot see the goblins anymore nor hear their calls, although Lizzie still can. Laura pines for the fruit, losing her health and youthful vigor. After some futile attempts to plant the fruit pit, Laura despairs. She stops eating and working.

Lizzie fears that Laura will die soon, so she places a silver penny in her purse and goes to the goblin men. She asks for fruit for her sister, but the goblins instead invite Lizzie to join their feast. When she refuses, the goblins beat her and try to force the fruit into her mouth, smearing her face with juice. She does not succumb, and the goblins soon tire of torturing her.

Lizzie returns home and tells Laura to kiss the juice on her face, and Laura does so. The juice acts like a poison and Laura collapses into a deathlike state. Lizzie remains by her sister's side through the night and in the morning, Laura awakens, her health and beauty restored. Years later, when they are both married, the two sisters tell their children the tale of the goblin men. Laura ends the story with the moral, “there is no friend like a sister.”

Analysis:

This narrative poem has an irregular rhyme scheme and loose iambic tetrameters, which quickens the pace. The loose meter allows for the narrators' spontaneity, and the rapid pace lends a tone of urgency. Lizzie and Laura, the narrators, deliver the poem as a lesson to their children.

There are two popular interpretations of “Goblin Market”: one reading is religious, and the other focuses on gender and sexuality. Because it is difficult to prove Rossetti's original intent, scholars have invented a useful dichotomy. If the reader is more familiar with the religion, the reader will see the Christian allegory. However, if the reader is well versed in the study of gender and sexuality, then the symbolism will more readily relate to that topic. These interpretations are not mutually exclusive; rather, they should be viewed in tandem to extract the maximum meaning from this poem.

In the Christian interpretation, Laura represents Eve, the goblin men are the equivalent of Satan, their fruit is the temptation to sin, and Lizzie is the Christ figure. Laura sins by going against the interdiction that she must not eat the goblins' fruit, which is an homage to Adam and Eve eating the forbidden fruit in the Book of Genesis. The long list of the goblins' fruit represents the wide variety of temptations that humans face during their lifetimes. Like Adam and Eve, Laura discovers that the fruit does not bring fulfillment, but rather, death and destruction.

Meanwhile, Lizzie suffers the consequences of Laura's sin in order to rescue her sister from the punishment of death, just like Christ. The red fruit juice that Lizzie tries to get Laura to drink is like the blood of Christ in the Eucharist. Rossetti describes Lizzie as a pure "lily in a flood," and that is why she is the only person who is able to save Laura's life. The sacrifice Lizzie makes for her sister comes out of pure love and true friendship.

The second interpretation of "Goblin Market" is based on symbols of repressed sexual desire and sexual violence. Lizzie and Laura are both innocent and virginal at the beginning of the poem, but Laura's curiosity proves to be stronger than her sister's warning. Rossetti creates an uncomfortable struggle between the consequences of pursuing lust and the need to explore natural human desires. Amidst charged language like "sucked" and "heaved," Laura loses her youth and bloom (her virginity, essentially) as a result of taking the goblin men's tempting fruit. In Victorian society, a woman's deflowering marks her transition into adulthood as a wife and mother. However, because Laura is not married, the encounter strips her of her "maiden" status prematurely. Laura did not heed her sister's warning, and now, just like Jeanie, she will suffer.

Lizzie's trajectory in this interpretation, however, is not quite as straightforward. Rossetti uses the language of sexual violence when the goblin men attack her with fruit, but Lizzie refuses to drink the juice. Meanwhile, she manages to hold onto her virtue in the form of the silver penny, which has a double meaning - "silver penny" was an Elizabethan term for the female genitalia. Lizzie makes a sacrifice so that Laura can heal and recover. However, the difficulty of this interpretation is that lost maidenhood cannot be recovered. Instead, Laura's redemption could be refer to her reintroduction into normal social relationships, because at the end of the poem, she is married with children.

The motto, "there is no friend like a sister," coincides with the feminist theme. Sisterhood and female community were important to Rossetti, who worked with prostitutes at the St. Mary Magdalene Home for Fallen Women. Perhaps she hoped that through this poem, even fallen women could seek a path to redemption, leaving their past indiscretions behind. However, there is a darker side to the feminist interpretation. Much of the language in "Goblin Market" refers to buying and selling. In Victorian England, women were expected to follow a certain standard of conduct. Failure to meet these standards led to the depreciation of a woman's worth when she came to the marriage "market." Unlike Laura, Lizzie heeds the warning and safeguards her money in her purse, thereby protecting her maidenly virtue.

UNIT-5

History of 19th Century British Literature

The 19th-century British literature encompasses all the works that were written and published between 1800 and 1900. Most of the works of this period fall within the

Victorian era which is between the years 1832 and 1900. The paper addresses the most outstanding features of British literature of this age.

19th Century British Literature

The nineteenth century, like no other single century before or since, was for the inhabitants of the British Isles an era of change. The general population would nearly triple while some twenty million Britons--driven by desire and, in many cases, desperation--emigrated to destinations across the globe. A vast internal migration at the same time turned villages and towns into large cities and made London the world's most populous urban center. And while various scientific enterprises disclosed the need to gauge the earth's history by factors of tens of millions of years, the rise of electrified, steam-powered systems for transport and communication were said to annihilate barriers of space and time. The size of the planet, many observed, seemed to shrink even as astronomers and physicists began to imagine an expanding universe of infinite scope.

These transformations were only the backdrop for further social change born in class conflict and various demands for equality before the law. As industrialization in general accelerated forms of material production, writers expressed their creativity in experimental, innovative literary forms. Narratives of self-invention achieved prominence while tradition was mined in an effort to adjust to the disorienting advent of modernity. Popular genres—notably the domestic novel and a new colloquial poetry of everyday life—would gain influence and prestige. But democratic and demotic literary manifestations would also be echoed and betrayed by authoritarian and hieratic notions of cultural authority.

In our teaching and research in Romanticism, we consider how the national epic and the romance tradition (as part of an alternative “classicism” as well as an interest in pre-modern England) are revised, and revived, often with proto-psychoanalytic and politically hegemonic undercurrents. In studies of the novel, as the century progresses, we are interested in the widening of readership and reading communities within an expanding public for the consumption of print media of all kinds. Other areas of emphasis include novel theory, Victorian material culture, book history (Who reads what and why? Who prevents whom from reading what and why?), the literary consequences of growing religious liberty, and the increasing dialogue between assertions of aesthetic value and notions of national or personal vitality.

The 19th century is also known as the **Victorian Era** since it nearly spans the reign of Queen Victoria from 1837-1901. During this time, the British Empire expanded; with a stable government and growing economy due to the rise of industrialization, ampler amounts of people were experiencing social mobility. With the increase of social mobility, class divisions strengthened to separate the aristocracy from those moving up.

The first half of the 19th century was characterized by **Romanticism**, a literary, artistic, and intellectual movement focused on emotional expression. As scientific inquiry and industry became more prevalent, Romantic writers stepped away from urban life. They wrote heavily on nature, individualism, and the idea of the "**common man**"—the working class person reflective of everyday society. Following the Romantic and idealized portrayal of life, the mid-19th century shifted to the **Realism Movement**, which still represents ordinary people and everyday situations, but in a way that is more aligned with reality.

With greater access to publication, 19th-century writers used a multitude of forms to express their ideas and were not limited to specific genres. Prominent authors of this time are known for the ideas they express through their poetry, journals, fictional narratives, and novels. Authors were not limited by their genre. Some of the most prominent 19th-century include:

- Jane Austen
- William Wordsworth
- Percy Bysshe Shelley
- Charles Dickens
- Henry David Thoreau
- Emily Dickinson
- Louisa May Alcott
- Mark Twain

British Authors

Jane Austen (1775-1817) wrote novels centered around the romantic lives of her characters realistically. Her social commentary often centered around the lives of women in the 19th century, specifically their limited opportunities and the logistical benefits of marriage. Originally published anonymously, most of her novels became most popular in the 20th century among feminist critics; they include *Emma*, *Pride and Prejudice*, and *Sense and Sensibility*.

Nicknamed the "Poet of Nature," William Wordsworth (1770-1850) was a Romantic poet known for his lyrical ballads. He used poetry to express his love and appreciation for nature. He emphasized the need for "common speech" in writing so that poetry could be a way to understand the common man. His most

famous poem, "The Prelude," was an extensive piece that chronicles his entire life and emphasizes human interaction, spirituality, and the power of nature.